paganism. Our faith is destined to die and very soon, Nagaland will stop being the abode of Christ and will become the den of anti-Christ where idols will be worshipped and the heathen will rule.'[99] The Christian–Hindu binary became a key fault line of Naga identity. Liezietsu characterised it as a choice between 'outsiders' and 'Naga identity' and asked voters not to gamble with their 'faith, identity and culture'.[100]

The BJP responded to this challenge with two countermoves. It downplayed the Hindutva narrative in Nagaland, especially on the issue of beef. Further, it countered the outsider/anti-Christian charge by stitching together a new alliance with another regional party, the Nationalist Democratic Progressive Party (NDPP), which had emerged after a split within the then ruling NPF, a few months before the state went to the polls in 2018. The NPF split was caused by differences among its senior leaders and the BJP played what one observer called a 'masterly and shrewd tactical game' in managing the political fallout. It chose not to disown the parent NPF, which was also a BJP ally at the Centre. But it struck a parallel deal with the new NDPP just before the election. The BJP 'had calculated that the two were evenly matched and did not want to put all its eggs in one basket', *Imphal Press Journal* editor Pradip Phanjoubam observed. 'Given the power balance, the NPF could not muster the courage to protest the BJP move, nor did NDPP insist on the BJP severing ties with the NPF … Till the last moment before the BJP took the decision, both the NPF and NDPP were profusely pledging allegiance to the BJP.'[101]

The NPF had split into two halves with equal influence in the state, and one half, led by Neiphiu Rio, renamed itself as NDPP. The new party's breakaway leaders needed the BJP as a national ally in their fight with the NPF. So the new faction gave the BJP, a party that had won only one seat in Nagaland's previous state elections of 2013, the space to contest in as many as twenty seats in Nagaland's sixty-member assembly. With backing from NDPP cadres, the BJP won twelve of these seats, its highest ever performance so far in the state. Its best until then had been seven seats in 2003. The NDPP itself won eighteen seats, giving its alliance with the BJP a majority in the Nagaland assembly (see Table 16.5).